

Session 17: Egypt as Eden Tree, Sea Monster, and Nephilim

Key Takeaways

- Ezekiel carefully combines images and vocabulary from the first six chapters of Genesis to condemn Egypt as a force of both human and spiritual rebellion.
- Egypt is depicted as a beautiful giant tree that is torn down for its arrogance and as a chaotic sea monster that is caught and brought on land to be defeated.
- Genesis 3 tells two fall stories, one of human failure and one of a rebellious spiritual being. Ezekiel reflects on both realities when he uses Eden imagery in the oracle against Egypt.

Seven Oracles Against Egypt (Ezek. 29:1-32:32)

In the years before the fall of Jerusalem, Israel turned to Egypt for support and help against Babylon because it was the only political power that posed any kind of threat to Nebuchadnezzar. Jeremiah tried to compel the Jerusalemites to reject Egypt's help (unsuccessfully, see [Jer. 37:4-10](#)), and here Ezekiel sets himself to the same task by showing that Egypt is an arrogant, helpless ally against Yahweh's appointed servant Babylon.

#1 The Fall of the Sea-Monster (Ezek. 29:1-16)

Ezekiel uses a traditional image from Canaanite mythology: the great sea-dragon who represents all forces opposed to Yahweh and who is slain and destroyed when Yahweh brings his justice. This backstory is echoed in [Psalm 74:13-14](#), [89:9-10](#), [Isaiah 27:1](#), [51:9](#), and [Job 7:12](#). This figure is also named "Rahab" and was a common prophetic image for Egypt, see [Isaiah 30:7](#). Pharaoh is reduced to the image of a crocodile (common in the Nile) captured and left to rot in the desert.

#2 Egypt Will Fall in Place of Tyre (Ezek. 29:17-21)

Ezekiel had predicted that Tyre would be besieged and destroyed by Babylon (chapters 26-28, dated to 586 B.C.E.). As it turned out, Nebuchadnezzar's siege of Tyre was prolonged for 13 years (cross-reference with Josephus, *Against Apion*, 1.4), and he was never able to overcome the city's defense. Babylon and Tyre reached some kind of settlement, and Tyre did acquiesce to Babylonian authority after this point, but Ezekiel's prophecy of the city's destruction was not fulfilled exactly as he predicted.

Does this make Ezekiel a false prophet? Some apparently thought so (see [Ezek. 12:23-28](#)). But in this oracle (dated 15 years after chapters 26-28), Yahweh adjusts his previous word through Ezekiel: Egypt will be conquered by Babylon in place of Tyre and serve as a reward for the failed siege. Yahweh has freedom over his word to change how it may be fulfilled. This highlights two aspects of Ezekiel's prophecies that are key to consider.

1. Ezekiel's prophetic and poetic style employs a high degree of hyperbole, stereotyped phraseology, and intense rhetoric, all designed for maximum communicative impact. We should be wary of demanding too literal a fulfillment of his prophecies; Yahweh himself says so!
2. Biblical prophecy always has a contingent element so that predictions made in seemingly absolute terms may be adjusted if circumstances change or people respond in appropriate ways (Jon. 3 is a classic example).

"This little passage serves as a warning that even in Ezekiel's own day it was clear that there need not always be a literal fulfillment of the predictions he had made with his artistic poetic rhetoric. The fact that a prediction did not quickly 'come true' in literal terms did not mean that the prophetic word lost all authenticity or relevance. It is ironic that Ezekiel's prophecies have suffered under the labors of those determined to take some of his later visions with utter literalism. Such people use Ezekiel's words to predict all kinds of 'end times' scenarios, and their forecasts have manifestly failed to materialize as predicted (though not before they made a great deal of money!)."

Wright, Christopher J.H. (2001). [*The Message of Ezekiel: A New Heart and a New Spirit*](#). IVP Academic. 249-250.

"God is aware that the oracles against Tyre have not been fulfilled as originally delivered. But he will not be held captive even by his own word ... In their concern for the literal fulfillment of Ezekiel's predictions, his audience had overlooked the primary function of his preaching: to persuade them to repent of their sins and to acknowledge Yahweh, and to submit to his claims on their lives. Prophetic proclamation is more than fortune-telling; it is rhetorically charged with exuberance, passion, hyperbole, figurative language, and whatever means it will take to evoke a response in the hearer. Preoccupation with the fulfillment of predictions has a tendency to deafen hearers to the primary message of God and his agent in any age."

Block, Daniel (1998). [*The Book of Ezekiel, Chapters 25-48 \(The New International Commentary on the Old Testament\)*](#). Eerdmans.

#3 The Day of Yahweh Against Egypt (Ezek. 30:1-19)

Ezekiel 30:1-19 announces the day of the Lord coming against Egypt in the form of a lament for the astonishing downfall of Egypt and her allies.

#4 Egypt Broken by Babylon (Ezek. 30:20-26)

Ezekiel contrasts the broken arm of Pharaoh with the strengthened arm of the king of Babylon.

#5 The Fall of the Cosmic Tree—Pharaoh's Demise (Ezek. 31:1-18)

The comparison with Assyria in 31:3 is odd if the entire oracle is about Egypt. The poem is either (1) comparing Egypt's imminent downfall with Assyria's rise and fall or, (2) the poem is a scribal error that resulted in the change from "Cypress" to "Assyria," which would make sense of the concluding statement in 31:18.

The cosmic tree motif is another image Ezekiel takes up from his Mesopotamian cultural heritage (see Block's discussion of ancient Sumerian, Babylonian, and Ugaritic cosmic tree myths). Daniel 4 is the closest biblical

parallel (Jesus drew on both in his parables of the kingdom in Mark 4:30-32), and Ezekiel links the tree to the garden in Genesis 2.

¹ In the eleventh year,
in the third month,
on the first of the month,
the word of Yahweh came to me saying,

² "Son of human,
say to Pharaoh king of Egypt and to his hordes,
'Whom are you like in your greatness?

³ Look, Assyria was a cedar in Lebanon,
with beautiful branches and forest shade,
and tall of height,
and its top was among the clouds.

⁴ The waters made it grow big,
the deep-water made it high.
With its rivers it continually went all around its planting place,
and it sent out its channels to all the trees of the field.

⁵ Therefore its height was taller than all the trees of the field,
and its boughs became many,
and its branches long,
because of many waters as it spread them out.

⁶ All the birds of the heavens nested in its boughs,
and under its branches all the beasts of the field gave birth,
and all the many nations lived under its shade.

⁷ And it was beautiful in its greatness,
in the length of its branches;
for its roots extended to many waters.

⁸ The cedars in Elohim's garden could not match it;
the cypress could not compare with its boughs,
and the plane trees could not match its branches,
no tree in Elohim's garden could compare with it in its beauty,

⁹ I made it beautiful with the multitude of its branches,
and all the trees of Eden, which were in the garden of Elohim, were jealous of it.

¹⁰ Therefore thus says Yahweh Elohim,
"Because it is tall in height,
and has set its top among the clouds,
and its heart is lifted up in its height,

¹¹ so I will give it into the hand of the mighty one among the nations;
he will thoroughly deal with it.

According to its wickedness I have banished it.

¹² Foreign tyrants of the nations have cut it down and left it;
on the mountains and in all the valleys its branches have fallen,
and its boughs have been broken in all the ravines of the land,
and all the peoples of the land have gone down from its shade and left it.

¹³ On its fallen-form all the birds of the heavens will dwell,
and all the beasts of the field will be on its fallen branches,

¹⁴ so that all the trees by the waters may not be grow tall in their height,
nor set their top among the clouds,
nor their well-watered mighty ones stand up in their height.

For they have all been given over to death,
to the land underneath, among the sons of humanity, with those who go down to the pit.”

¹⁵ Thus says Yahweh God,
“On the day it went down to Sheol I caused mourning;
I closed the deep over it,
and held back its rivers,
and its many waters were stopped up,
and I made Lebanon lament for it,
and all the trees of the field wilted away on account of it.

¹⁶ I made the nations quake at the sound of its fall,
when I made it go down to Sheol with those who go down to the pit;
and all the well-watered trees of Eden, the choicest and best of Lebanon,
they were comforted in the land underneath.

¹⁷ They also went down with it to Sheol to those slain by the sword;
and those who were its strength lived under its shade among the nations.

¹⁸ To which of the trees of Eden are you thus equal in glory and greatness?
Yet you will be brought down with the trees of Eden to the land underneath;
you will lie down in the midst of the uncircumcised,
with those who were slain by the sword.
This is Pharaoh and all his hordes!”
utterance of Yahweh Elohim.”

Ezekiel 31:1-18. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

#6 A Dirge Over Pharaoh—The Great Sea Monster is Slain (32:1-16)

¹ And it came about in the twelfth year,
on the twelfth of the month,
on the first of the month,
the word of Yahweh came to me, saying:

² “Son of a human,
lift up a funeral poem for Pharaoh, king of Egypt,

and say to him,

‘You compared yourself to a young lion of the nations,
but you are like a sea-monster;
and you gushed forth in your rivers,
and you muddied the waters with your feet,
and you stomped their rivers.’

³ This is what Yahweh Elohim says,

‘Now I will spread my net over you,
with a company of many peoples,
and they will lift you up in my net,
⁴ and I will leave you on the land,
and I will hurl you on the open field,
and I will cause all the birds of the skies to dwell on you,
and I will satisfy the beasts of the whole earth with you,

⁵ I will set your flesh on the mountains,
and I will fill the valleys with your refuse,
⁶ and I will also make the land drink the flow of your blood,
unto the mountains,
and the ravines will be full of you.

⁷ And when I extinguish you,
I will cover the skies,
and I will darken their stars;
I will cover the sun with a cloud,
and the moon will not give its light.

⁸ All the shining lights in the skies I will darken over you,
and will set darkness on your land;
utterance of Yahweh Elohim.

⁹ I will provoke the hearts of many peoples,
when I bring about your breaking among the nations,
into lands which you have not known,
¹⁰ and I will make many peoples appalled at you,
and their kings will shudder a shuddering at you,
when I make my sword fly before them,
and they will tremble every moment,
every man for his own life,
on the day of your fall.”

¹¹ For thus says the Lord God,

“The sword of the king of Babylon will come upon you.

12 With the swords of the **mighty warriors** I will cause your horde to **fall** ;
all of them are tyrants of the nations,
and they will devastate the pride of Egypt,
and all its hordes will be destroyed,
13 and I will also destroy all its cattle from beside many waters,
and the foot of human will not stomp them anymore,
and the hoofs of beasts will not muddy them.
14 Then I will make their waters settle,
and will cause their rivers to run like oil,"
utterance of Yahweh Elohim.
15 "When I make the land of Egypt a desolation,
and the land is desolate from what fills it,
when I strike all those who live in it,
and they will know that I am Yahweh.

16 This is a funeral poem and they will chant it,
the daughters of the nations shall chant it,
over Egypt and over all her hordes they will chant it,"
utterance of Yahweh Elohim.

Ezekiel 32:1-16. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

#7 Pharaoh's Descent to the Netherworld (32:17-32)

17 In the twelfth year,
on the fifteenth of the month,
the word of Yahweh came to me saying,
18 "Son of man, wail for the hordes of Egypt,
and bring it down, her and the daughters of the powerful nations,
to the land underneath, with those who go down to the pit;
19 Whom do you surpass in beauty?
Go down and make your bed with the uncircumcised.
20 They **will fall** in the midst of those who are slain by the sword.
She is given over to the sword;
they have drawn her and all her hordes away.
21 The strong among the **mighty warriors** will speak of him and his helpers from the midst of Sheol,
'They have gone down,
the uncircumcised lie still,
slain by the sword.'
22 **Assyria** is there and all her company;
her graves are round about her.
All of them are slain, **fallen** by the sword,
23 whose graves are set in the remotest parts of the pit,

and her company is round about her grave.
All of them are slain, **fallen** by the sword,
who spread terror in the land of the living.

24 **Elam** is there and all her hordes around her grave;
all of them slain, **fallen** by the sword,
who went down uncircumcised to the land underneath,
who instilled their terror in the land of the living,
and bore their disgrace with those who went down to the pit.

25 Among the slain they have made a bed for her,
with all her horde around her is her grave,
they are all uncircumcised, slain by the sword,
for their terror was instilled in the land of the living,
and they bore their disgrace with those who go down to the pit;
they were put in the midst of the slain.

26 **Meshech, Tubal** and all their hordes are there; their graves surround them.
All of them were slain by the sword, uncircumcised,
for they instilled their terror in the land of the living.

27 Nor do they lie down beside the **mighty warriors**, **fallen** among the uncircumcised,
who went down to Sheol with their weapons of war,
and whose swords were laid under their heads;
but their guilt was upon their bones,
for the terror of these **mighty warriors** was once in the land of the living.

28 But in the midst of the uncircumcised you will be broken,
and you will lie with those slain by the sword.

29 **Edom** is there, its kings and all its chiefs,
who for all their might are laid with those slain by the sword;
they will lie with the uncircumcised,
and with those who go down to the pit.

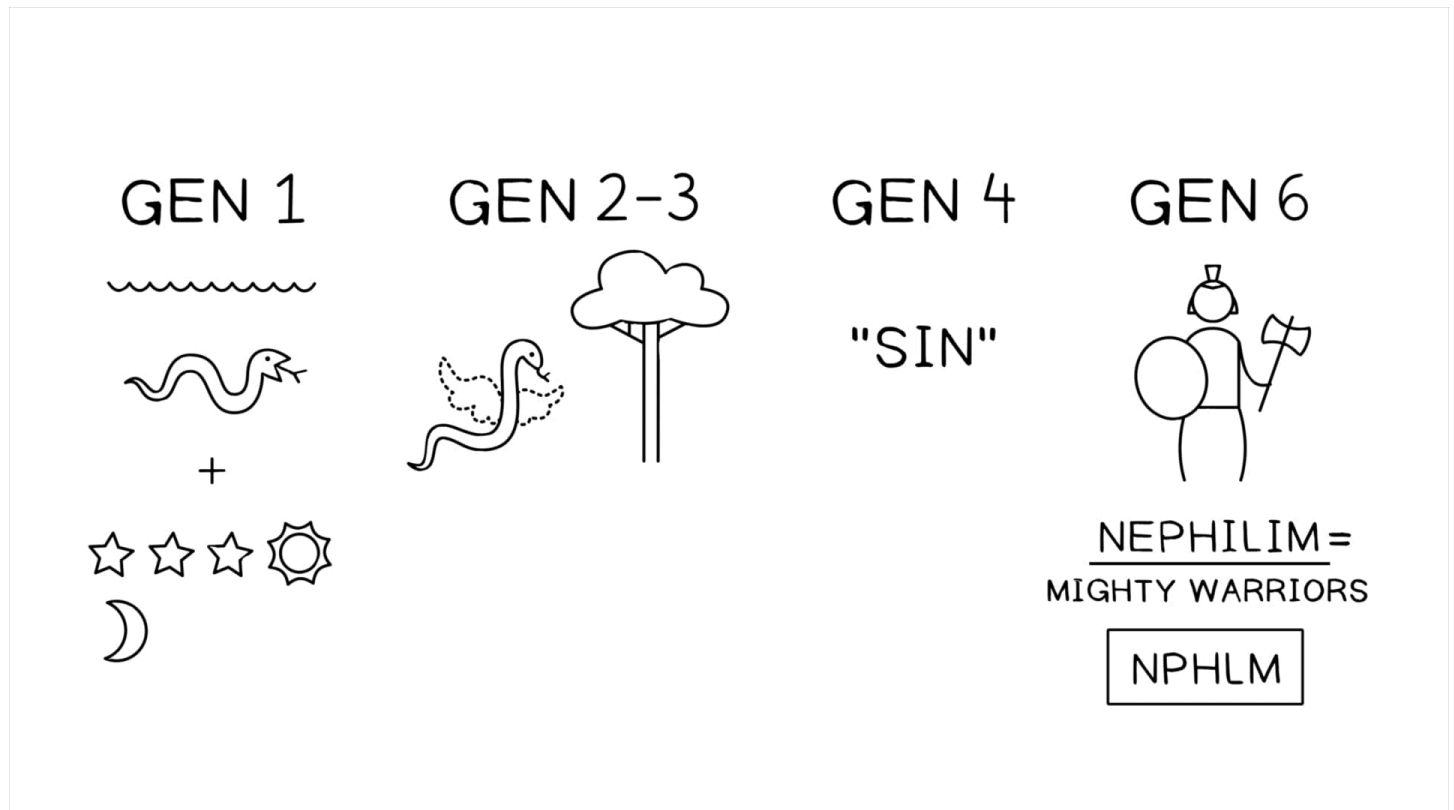
30 There are the **chiefs of the north**, all of them,
and all the **Sidonians**,
who in spite of the terror resulting from their might,
in shame went down with the slain,
so they lay down uncircumcised with those slain by the sword,
and they bore their disgrace with those who go down to the pit.

31 These Pharaoh will see,
and he will be comforted for all his hordes,
those slain by the sword, even Pharaoh and all his army,"
utterance of Yahweh Elohim.

³² "Though I instilled a terror of him in the land of the living,
yet he will be made to lie down among the uncircumcised,
along with those slain by the sword,
even Pharaoh and all his hordes,"
utterance of Yahweh Elohim.

Ezekiel 32:17-32. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Images of Spiritual Rebellion in Genesis 1-6



Images of Spiritual Rebellion in Genesis 1-6. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Reflection Question

How do you understand the relationship between corrupt human empires and rebellious spiritual beings?